Pneumonia

Pneumonia is inflammation of the lungs, usually caused by an infection. Most people get better in 2 to 4 weeks, but babies, older people, and people with heart or lung conditions are at risk of getting seriously ill and may need treatment in hospital.

Symptoms of pneumonia

Symptoms of pneumonia can start suddenly or gradually over a few days.

They include:

- a cough – you may cough up yellow or green mucus (phlegm)
- shortness of breath
- a high temperature
- chest pain
- an aching body
- feeling very tired
- loss of appetite
- making wheezing noises when you breathe – babies may also make grunting noises
- feeling confused – this is common in older people

Ask for an urgent GP appointment or get help from NHS 111 if:

- you've had a cough for 3 weeks or more
- you're coughing up blood
- you have chest pain that comes and goes, or happens when breathing or coughing
- you're feeling short of breath

You can call 111 or get help from 111 online (Link: https://111.nhs.uk/triage/check-your-symptoms).

Call 999 if:

- you're struggling to breathe – you're choking, gasping and unable to speak
- you have pale, blue or blotchy skin, lips or tongue
- you suddenly feel confused – for example, you do not know where you are
- you cannot wake your baby and they feel floppy

> Do not drive yourself to A&E.
>
> The person you speak to at 999 will give you advice about what to do.

Treatment for pneumonia

You'll usually be given antibiotics to treat pneumonia. Most people get better in 2 to 4 weeks.

Some people are more at risk of becoming seriously ill. You may need to go to hospital for treatment if:

- you're over 65
- you have cardiovascular disease (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/cardiovascular-disease/) or a long-term lung condition
- your baby or young child has pneumonia
- you're very unwell
- you're not getting better after taking antibiotics

In hospital you'll usually be given fluids, antibiotics, and sometimes steroids, to treat the infection. You may also be given oxygen to help you breathe.

You may be sent for an X-ray (Link: www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/x-ray/) of your chest and blood tests to check for other conditions.

Important

If you're given antibiotics to take at home, contact your doctor if you do not feel better after taking them for 2 to 3 days.

Things you can do if you have pneumonia

There are some things you can do to help with recovery from pneumonia and reduce the risk of spreading it to other people.

Do

- ✔ rest until you feel better – try to stay at home and avoid contact with other people if you have a high temperature or do not feel well enough to do normal activities
- ✔ drink plenty of fluids
- ✔ take paracetamol (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/paracetamol-for-adults/) or ibuprofen (Link: www.nhs.uk/medicines/ibuprofen-for-adults/) to help with pain or a high temperature
- ✔ cover your mouth and nose with a tissue when you cough or sneeze
- ✔ put used tissues in the bin as quickly as possible
- ✔ wash your hands regularly with water and soap

Don’t

- ✘ do not take cough medicine – coughing helps your body get rid of the infection
- ✘ do not smoke

Causes of pneumonia

Pneumonia is usually caused by a bacterial or viral infection.

You can catch pneumonia from someone who has it, or you can sometimes get it if you have another infection such as:

- flu (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/flu/)
- respiratory syncytial virus (RSV) (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/respiratory-syncytial-virus-rsv/)

- COVID-19 (Link: www.nhs.uk/conditions/covid-19/)

Pneumonia can be caused by a fungal infection, but this is rare in healthy people in the UK.

It may also be caused by something getting into your lungs, such as water or food (aspiration pneumonia).

How to reduce your risk of pneumonia

There are several vaccines available to help protect you or your child from infections that can cause pneumonia:

- pneumococcal vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/pneumococcal-vaccine/) – recommended for babies, adults over 65 and people at higher risk of pneumococcal infections
- flu vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/flu-vaccine/) – recommended during pregnancy, for adults over 65, people with certain long-term health conditions and those at high risk of catching or passing on flu
- RSV vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/rsv-vaccine/) – recommended for adults aged 75 to 79, and during pregnancy (from 28 weeks onwards) to help protect your baby after they're born
- COVID-19 vaccine (Link: www.nhs.uk/vaccinations/covid-19-vaccine/) – a seasonal vaccine that's recommended for people at increased risk from COVID-19

> Stopping smoking also reduces your chance of getting pneumonia.

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24 pneumonia studies in the UK are currently looking for people like you to take part.

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